

DRAGGING THEIR FEET

JULY 2006

State home minister gives an "in principle" approval to SID's makeover.

OCTOBER 2006

The SID gives its proposal to the home ministry for examination.

JUNE 2007

GR issued notifying the state cabinet's approval of the plan.

NOVEMBER 2007

Recruitment rules still being finalised by GAD and law ministry.

FEBRUARY 2008

The recruitment expected to begin, according to the deputy chief minister.



proper to pin the blame, but the delay mainly took place because of the struggle to clearly conceptualise the makeover by the home ministry. GAD and law ministry took more time as they were dealing with a complicated task and had no prior experience."

Patil, though, does not think there has been a delay. "Reconstituting sid is my dream project. I want to bring it at par with the best in the country. Once it is done, our sid will be the first state intelligence agency that will have its own directly-recruited cadre trained specially by the Intelligence Bureau (IB). It is a huge challenge and needs time. But now, within three months the process for direct recruitment will be wrapped up," he says. On being further probed, he says, "The reconstitution involved framing of service and recruitment rules and getting the financial allocation approved by the legislature. It is a time-consuming process, thus the delay, if that is what you want to call it."

But sid can scarcely afford to wait too long for its revamp, considering the challenges it needs to begin
TOO SLOW: Police headquarters; site of 2006 Mumbai blasts (far left)

ing the challenges it needs to begin bracing up to. According to the revamp proposal, the department, with a total strength of 1,035 today, needs a special cadre of officers that will constitute half its total strength in future. This cadre will be trained by IB. The new recruits will have to master either Urdu or Arabic apart from Marathi, Hindi, English and one optional language. In Mumbai—where at present there is only a 10-man unit focusing on both political and communal trouble-makers—two new field units will be set up exclusively for tracking terror, one each for the island city and the suburbs.

But time is fast running out. According to IB alerts received by the state police, two alleged Pakistani suicide bombers arrived in the city in August to achieve a "high-value" target, which includes Shiv Sena chief Bal Thackeray. In the same month, five other Bangladeshi terrorists too managed to sneak into the city to target mosques and dargahs. sid could have been spearheading this operation. Instead it is still an idea floating on paper in the Mantralaya. ■

